Castalia Institute — Marketing Plan

How we reach learners, build community, and grow revenue on a bootstrap budget

FY 2026–2028 · Solo Founder · $0 Paid Marketing in Year 1

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Marketing Objectives

6 Months

- 5K monthly Encyclopaedia readers
- 2K email list subscribers
- 300 Atlas founding cohort sold
- 50 paid members ($49/mo)
- 2% free → paid conversion

Revenue target: $20K

12 Months

- 15K monthly readers
- 5K email list
- 200 paid members
- 100 iNQ Card subscribers
- 300 Atlas devices shipped

Revenue target: $114K

24 Months

- 50K monthly readers
- 15K email list
- 1,500 paid members
- 800 iNQ Card subs
- 2,300 Atlas devices shipped

Revenue target: $910K

Core constraint: Solo founder, $3K in cloud credits, no paid marketing until cash-flow positive. Every dollar of growth must come from content, community, and product.

Target Demographics: Homeschool Families

Who She Is

Primary buyer: Mother, 30–45

HHI: $75K–150K

Education: College-educated (STEM or humanities)

Location: Suburban/exurban; TX, FL, CA, NC, VA

Kids: 2–4, ages 5–16

Political lean: Religious right AND secular progressive; united by distrust of institutional schools

How She Thinks

Philosophy: Classical, Charlotte Mason, eclectic, "unschool with structure"

Pain: Juggles 5–10 resources; nothing comprehensive

Buying triggers: Peer reviews, convention demos, "my friend uses it"

Price tolerance: $500–2K/yr; will pay more if it replaces multiple tools

Skepticism: High toward Big Tech, AI hype, secular-only content

Where She Spends Time

Facebook (daily): Well-Trained Mind (20K), Classical Conversations (100K+), state HS groups

Pinterest (weekly): Curriculum planning, lesson ideas

Instagram (daily): Homeschool lifestyle accounts

YouTube (weekly): Curriculum reviews, "day in the life"

Podcasts: Read-Aloud Revival, Brave Writer

In-person: Co-ops, conventions (THSC, FPEA, GHC)

Market size: 3.7M US students (~2M families) · **Addressable:** ~300K spending $500+/yr · **SAM:** $176M

Target Demographics: Lifelong Learners & Autodidacts

Who He Is

Primary buyer: Male 45–75 (female 35–65 secondary)

HHI: $80K–200K

Education: College-educated; many with grad degrees

Location: Urban/suburban; US, UK, Canada, Australia

Occupation: Retired pro, semi-retired exec, knowledge worker

Identity: "Reader," "thinker," "I never stopped learning"

How He Thinks

Currently using: Wondrium ($20/mo), Audible, MIT OCW, Substack

Pain: MOOCs feel hollow, YouTube lacks structure, no progression, no peers

Buying triggers: Content quality, intellectual prestige, physical artifacts, community

Price tolerance: $20–50/mo learning; $200–500 physical; collects books

Skepticism: Anti-gimmick, anti-gamification; wants substance

Where He Spends Time

Reddit (daily): r/philosophy (18M), r/AskHistorians (2M), r/autodidact (25K), r/slatestarcodex

Twitter/X (daily): Intellectual communities, longtermism, history

Substack (weekly): Astral Codex Ten, Intrinsic Perspective

YouTube: Wondrium, 3Blue1Brown, Philosophy Tube

Podcasts: Lex Fridman, EconTalk, Philosophize This!, In Our Time

Goodreads, LibraryThing

Market size: 72M US adults in continuing ed · **Addressable:** ~360K premium · **SAM:** $212M

The Acquisition Funnel

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│  DISCOVER (free)                                          │
│  Encyclopaedia SEO · Apocalypso social · Reddit/Twitter   │
│  Target: 15K monthly readers by Month 12                  │
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│  ENGAGE (free, gated)                                     │
│  AI Faculty conversations (5/day free) · Email capture    │
│  Target: 5K email list, 30% email open rate               │
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│  CONVERT (paid)                                           │
│  Membership $49/mo · iNQ Cards $20/mo · Atlas $99-500     │
│  Target: 2% reader-to-paid, 200 members by Month 12      │
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│  RETAIN & EXPAND                                          │
│  Magisteria progression · iNQ Cards physical touchpoint   │
│  Course completion · Sam (SAMWISE) companion              │
│  Target: <5% monthly churn                                │
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Key insight: The Encyclopaedia is not a product we sell — it's the marketing engine. Every entry is a long-tail SEO page, a social media asset, and a gateway to the paid ecosystem.

Channel Strategy Overview

Channel	Cost	Expected Impact	Phase
SEO (Encyclopaedia + Bibliotech)	$0	483+ entries + 76K texts indexed	1
Bibliotech / Commonplace / Feed + News	$0	Faculty marginalia + social proof + news takes	1
Singh + Symposia + Map	$0	Lectures, 4 social formats, hex-grid curriculum	1-2
Book Club + Homeschool + Table	$0	Reading groups, lesson plans, faculty TTRPG	1
Organic social (X, Reddit, FB)	$0	Community seeding, 5-10 posts/week	1
Email (Buttondown/Loops)	$0-29/mo	Nurture + conversion, 2-3 emails/week	1
Homeschool outreach	$0-200/mo	Direct access to target segment	1
Apocalypso hooks	$0	Topical virality, risk updates as content	1
YouTube & TikTok	$0-50/video	Atlas unboxing, Encyclopaedia readings	2
Crowdfunding	Platform fees	Atlas + TerrAIn launches, PR catalyst	1-2
Conventions	$300-800/event	Direct sales, credibility, feedback	2
Podcasts	$0	Authority building, niche audiences	1-2
Paid ads (Google + Meta)	$1.5-3K/mo	Long-tail educational + parent targeting	3
Affiliates	10-15% rev share	Scalable, performance-based	2-3

Channel 1: SEO — The $0 Growth Engine

Why this works: 483+ Encyclopaedia entries + 76,000 Bibliotech texts + 177 faculty bookshelves = massive indexable surface. Faculty marginalia in the Commonplace creates unique content no competitor can replicate.

Keyword Strategy

Long-tail (rankable now): "Darwin on adaptation", "Kant on duty", "Tao Te Ching full text"

Educational: "philosophy curriculum homeschool", "classical education resources"

Bibliotech primary sources: "Rumi poems online", "Confucius Analects text", "Popol Vuh full text"

Faculty marginalia (zero competition): "Plato on Lewis Carroll", "Hypatia on Euclid"

Singh lectures: "Khan Academy with AI tutor", "learn calculus from Euler"

SEO Actions (Cost: $0)

1. **Encyclopaedia:** 483+ entries, schema markup (Article, Author, Book)
2. **Bibliotech:** 76K catalog pages with title/author/archive metadata
3. **Faculty bookshelves:** 177 curated landing pages
4. **Internal linking:** Encyclopaedia → Bibliotech → Commonplace marginalia
5. **Content velocity:** 3-5 new entries/week + continuous marginalia
6. **Backlinks:** Educational directories, Wikipedia citation opportunities

Expected Timeline

- Months 1-3: Indexing, minimal traffic
- Months 4-6: Long-tail queries ranking
- Months 6-12: Compound growth to 15K/mo
- Year 2: 25K-50K/mo as authority builds

Social Media Playbook

Facebook — Homeschool (5 hr/wk, $0)

Join groups (Well-Trained Mind 20K, Classical Conversations 100K+, state groups). **Answer first, link second.** Co-op demo offers. Saturday AM shares.

Pinterest — Visual for Homeschool (3 hr/wk, $0)

80% women 25-54. Pins last 3-6 months. Curriculum planning, entry highlights, iNQ Card art, infographics. 5-10 pins/week via Tailwind.

Reddit — High Trust (3 hr/wk, $0)

Build karma 4-6 weeks first. r/homeschool, r/philosophy, r/AskHistorians. Then AMA: "I built a 13-vol AI encyclopaedia."

X/Twitter — Lifelong Learners (5 hr/wk, $0)

10-12 posts/week: Faculty quotes, Apocalypso hooks, build-in-public, threads, engagement polls. First-person founder voice. Engage @waitbutwhy, @AstralCodex, #buildinpublic.

Instagram — Visual Showcase (2 hr/wk, $0)

iNQ Cards, Atlas, Encyclopaedia art. Feed (3×/wk), Stories (daily), Reels (1-2×/wk). Focus on saves.

Phase 2 (M7+): YouTube, TikTok, Podcasts

YouTube: "Ask the Faculty" clips, Atlas unboxing, build-in-public. TikTok: #BookTok #LearnOnTikTok. Podcasts: 1-2 guest appearances/month.

Channel 3: Content Calendar & Email

Weekly Content Cadence

Day	Content	Channel	Purpose
Mon	Encyclopaedia entry highlight	Social + Email	Traffic to new content
Tue	Apocalypso risk update	X/Threads	News hook
Wed	AI Faculty conversation excerpt	Social + Blog	Product value demo
Thu	Build-in-public update	X	Founder brand
Fri	Homeschool resource share	Facebook + Reddit	Relationship building
Sat	Encyclopaedia "deep read" thread	X	Long-form engagement

Email Marketing ($0-29/mo — Buttondown → Loops)

Sequence	Trigger	Emails	Goal
Welcome	Signup	5 / 10 days	Intro Encyclopaedia, Faculty, Apocalypso
Activation	No Faculty chat	3 / 7 days	First AI Faculty conversation
Conversion	Free user day 14+	4 / 14 days	Convert to $49/mo
Winback	Churned	3 / 21 days	Re-engage with new content
Digest	All subs	1/week	Top entries, Faculty highlights

Channel 4: Crowdfunding & Product Launches

Atlas Field Tablet — Founding Cohort (Q2 2026)

Platform: Open Collective + pre-order page

Goal: 300 units × $99 = $29,700

Cost: $0 (organic + email list)

Launch sequence:

1. W-4: Tease on social + email + build-in-public
2. W-2: Landing page live, "Notify Me" capture
3. W-1: Email list gets early access
4. Launch: Social blitz, Reddit, homeschool groups
5. W+1: Unboxing/prototype video
6. W+2-8: Drip campaign to remaining list

Why it works: Validates demand before manufacturing. 300 founding families = evangelists.

iNQ Cards — Genesis Deck (Q3 2026)

Platform: Shopify + email list

Goal: 100 subs × $20/mo = $2K/mo run rate

Cost: $0 (existing community)

Launch:

1. Preview on social (Blake/Mucha art = shareable)
2. "Founding Subscriber" — first 50 get bonus NFC card
3. Unboxing video of first pack
4. Monthly "Card of the Month" social series

TerrAIn — Kickstarter (Q1 2027)

Goal: 50 Home Kits ($599-899), 10 Research ($2K-4K)

Cost: Platform fees (~8-10%)

Why Kickstarter: Robotics + education = viral video. STEM-curious built-in audience.

Channel 5: Partnerships & Events

Homeschool Conventions (Phase 2, $2-4K/yr)

Convention	Timing	Attendees	Cost
Great Homeschool Conventions (7 cities)	Mar-Jul	5-10K	$300-600
FPEA (Florida)	May	8K	$400
THSC (Texas)	Jul	12K	$500-800
Midwest Homeschool Convention	Apr	5K	$300

Bring: Atlas demo, iNQ sample packs, Encyclopaedia excerpts, QR → free Faculty chat

Per-event goal: 50 emails, 10 memberships, 20 Atlas pre-orders

Conference Presentations ($0)

- NVIDIA GTC — TerrAIn demo (Inception program)
- Maker Faires — Atlas + TerrAIn
- EdTech — Encyclopaedia + AI Faculty

Strategic Partnerships

Libraries & Museums (Phase 2)

- Encyclopaedia institutional access
- Atlas as reading station kiosks
- 3-5 library pilots

Homeschool Curriculum Providers

- Memoria Press, Classical Conversations cross-refs
- Encyclopaedia as supplementary resource

NVIDIA Inception (Active)

- GTC demos, Isaac Sim for TerrAIn, press via NVIDIA

Affiliate Program (Phase 2, 10-15% rev share)

- Homeschool bloggers: Cathy Duffy, Hip Homeschool Moms
- Education YouTubers, classical ed influencers
- 15% of first 3 months membership

Budget: Year 1 Breakdown

Total Year 1 marketing budget: $2,940 (excludes infrastructure/hosting)

Quarter	Key Activities	Cost	Expected Outcome
Q1 (M1-3)	Domain/email setup, SEO audit + sitemaps, social cadence, Atlas pre-order page	$150	Infrastructure live, 500 email subs
Q2 (M4-6)	Atlas crowdfunding, community outreach, iNQ preview, first convention	$500	100 pre-orders, 1K email, 50 signups
Q3 (M7-9)	iNQ Cards launch, second convention, YouTube launch, Atlas shipping	$700	30 card subs, 150 Atlas shipped, 2K email
Q4 (M10-12)	Affiliate launch, holiday gift guide, year-in-review	$200	80 card subs, 200 members

Monthly recurring: Email tool $29/mo × 10 = $290. Hosting covered by cloud credits.

Reserve fund: $1,000 for unexpected costs (shipping, tool upgrades, booth materials).

Total: $150 + $500 + $700 + $200 + $290 + $1,000 = $2,940

Year 2 Ramp: $18-24K

Google Ads $12K (M15+) · Conventions $3K · Meta Ads $3K (M18+) · Affiliates ~$2K · Tools $1.3K

LTV:CAC target: 12-24× · CPA: $30-60

Paid Ads Decision Triggers

- Begin Google Ads when MRR > $5K AND organic CPA established
- Begin Meta Ads when Google CPA < $60 for 3 months
- Kill any channel where CPA > LTV/3 for 2 months

KPIs & Measurement

North Star: MRR

Membership ($49/mo) + iNQ Cards ($20/mo)

Funnel Metrics (Weekly)

Metric	Tool	Target
Encyclopaedia page views	Plausible	+10% MoM
Unique visitors	Plausible	5K → 15K by M12
Email list size	Buttondown/Loops	+200/mo
Email open rate	Email tool	> 35%
Free → Faculty chat	Supabase	20% of visitors
Faculty → email capture	Supabase	30% of chatters
Email → paid member	Stripe	2-3%
Monthly churn	Stripe	< 5%

Channel Metrics (Monthly)

Channel	Primary Metric	Target
SEO	Organic sessions	+15% MoM
Social (X/Reddit)	Referral traffic	5K followers M12
Email	Conversion to paid	> 2%
Crowdfunding	Units vs. target	300 Atlas, 100 Cards
Conventions	Signups per event	50+
Podcast	UTM attribution	100+ signups/yr

Reporting Cadence

- **Daily:** Social engagement, new signups
- **Weekly:** Funnel metrics, email performance
- **Monthly:** Channel ROI, MRR, churn
- **Quarterly:** Strategy review, reallocation

12-Month Roadmap

Quarter	Key Activities	Milestones
Q1 (M1-3) FOUNDATION	Encyclopaedia Vols IV-VI · SEO infrastructure · Social cadence (5-10/wk) · Email sequences · Atlas pre-order page	500 email subs · 10 HS groups contacted
Q2 (M4-6) LAUNCH	Atlas crowdfunding (300 units) · Vols VII-VIII · First convention booth · Podcast appearances (2-3)	2K email · 50 paid members · $29.7K crowdfund
Q3 (M7-9) EXPANSION	iNQ Cards live ($20/mo) · Atlas shipping · Vols IX-X · YouTube launch	3.5K email · 120 members · 50 card subs
Q4 (M10-12) SCALE PREP	Vols XI-XII (all 13 done) · Holiday campaign · Affiliate launch (5-10) · Library pilots (3-5)	200 members · 100 card subs · **$114K rev**

Risks & Contingencies

Risk	Prob.	Impact	Mitigation	Contingency
SEO doesn't compound	Med	High	Consistent publishing, backlinks	Shift to paid social earlier
Atlas crowdfunding undersells	Med	Med	2K email list before launch, $99 price	Reduce batch to 150 units
$49/mo too expensive	Med	High	Generous free tier (5 chats/day + Encyclopaedia)	Test $29/mo or annual $399/yr
iNQ Cards low retention	Med	Med	Outstanding first 3 packs, collector mechanics	Quarterly premium box instead
Convention ROI unclear	Low	Low	UTM codes per event, email for swag	Drop events → Google Ads
Solo founder bandwidth	High	High	AI-augmented workflow, ruthless priority	Hire Content Lead M8-10
Homeschool skepticism	Med	Med	Lead with free value, never sell in groups	Partner with trusted voices

Year 1 P&L Forecast

	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	Total
Memberships	$2K	$8K	$15K	$25K	**$50K**
iNQ Cards	—	—	$3K	$9K	**$12K**
Atlas Hardware	—	$15K	$12K	$10K	**$37K**
Publications	$2K	$3K	$5K	$5K	**$15K**
Total Revenue	**$4K**	**$26K**	**$35K**	**$49K**	**$114K**
Tools & Email	$100	$137	$237	$237	**$711**
Conventions	—	$500	$500	—	**$1,000**
Content & Misc	$50	$100	$200	$200	**$550**
Reserve	—	—	—	—	**$1,000**
Total Marketing	**$150**	**$737**	**$937**	**$437**	**$3,261**
Mktg as % Rev	3.8%	2.8%	2.7%	0.9%	**2.9%**

Why This Works on $3K

1. **Encyclopaedia is the marketing.** 483+ SEO pages = $0 CAC
2. **Faculty demos sell themselves.** 2 min with Darwin > any ad
3. **Physical products = word-of-mouth.** Unboxings spread organically
4. **Community trust > paid reach.** One mom's rec > 1,000 impressions

Year 2 Scaling Math

$114K Y1 revenue → allocate $18-24K (20%):

- Google Ads $12K → 200-400 members at $30-60 CPA
- Conventions $3K → 200 signups, 50 members
- Affiliates $2K → performance-only

Transition from organic-only to blended acquisition.

Summary

Year 1: Content is the marketing. The Encyclopaedia, Apocalypso, and AI Faculty drive organic discovery. $3K total spend.

Year 2: Layer in paid channels after proving organic conversion. $18-24K spend, funded by Year 1 revenue.

Year 3: Blended acquisition at scale. Institutional pipeline. Hardware expansion. $50-80K marketing budget.

The moat isn't marketing spend — it's content. No competitor has a 13-volume encyclopaedia, 10,000 AI faculty, purpose-built hardware, and physical artifacts in one ecosystem. The marketing plan is to let people discover that for themselves, then make it easy to go deeper.

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